

Seftis-Kotad

An imagining

I

Deep below the darkest waters
In the ocean's secret trenches
Down into the stygian darkness
Where the seabed spews its sulphur
And the viscid water's silence
Drowns all trace of light and reason
Hunched and huge in muddy mantle
Sleeps the loathsome Seftis-Kotad
Reason killer, light destroyer.

Soundly sleeping from his labours
Seftis-Kotad had no equal
For obscuring light of wisdom
For devising superstition
For inventing gods and demons
For suppressing thought and clearness.
Fifty thousand years he laboured
Secretly among the people
Whispering lies and feigning shrewdness
Forging falsehood, teaching dogma
Spawning shamans, warlocks, witches
Raising priests, empowering prophets
All across the oikoumene
That the people might be mastered
And their understanding narrowed
And be forced into delusion
And be fearful of their dying.

Seftis-Kotad, never ceasing
By religion fostered hatred
Falsehood versus falsehood setting
Persecuting unbelievers
Demonising deviation
Casting out the voice of reason
Brooking not one contradiction.
He made rules of domination
Choice depriving, pleasure banning
Girls and women subjugating
Each infraction cruelly punished
Till each thought with guilt was laden.
On his grim and cankered planting
Seftis-Kotad fed with relish
Feeding on the hate and warfare
Feeding on the pain and anger
Feeding on corrupted wisdom.
Then at last, his hunger sated
Down he sank in torpid stupor
Slumped into his foetid chasm.

II

But within his ravaged wasteland
Tiny shoots of knowledge sprouted
Spry but often swiftly strangled.
All too few emerged and flourished
Persecuting pontiffs dodging
Past the powerful clerics creeping
Through the priested thickets edging
Tiny sparks amid the darkness.

Sky-turned faces, watching, marking

Evidence amassing slowly
Speculating, postulating
Doubting dogma, testing theories
Ptolomeic doctrine quashing
Truth-revealing, science shaping.

Dauntless voyage of exploration
Seeking in the distant islands
Found new beasts and birds of beauty.
Careful lithic observation
Found the trace of ancient lifeforms
Prompting questions of creation.
From these signs ideas unfolded
Revolutionary thinking
Challenging religious tenets
Scorn and mockery both outlasting.

Men of science, brilliant thinkers
Gradually dispelled the darkness
Shedding light on what is truthful
Undermining superstition.
As the tides of knowledge broadened
Reason breached delusion's strongholds
And the people started doubting
And their worship slowly withered
And the priesthood's sway diminished.
Girls and women, subjugated,
Found their power, their freedom relished
Pleasure was no longer banished
And the search for knowledge flourished
And the people amply prospered.

III

Deep below the darkest waters
In the ocean's secret trenches
Where the viscid water's silence
Drowns all trace of light and reason
Hunched and huge in muddy mantle
Dreamt the loathsome Seftis-Kotad.
Troubled dreams, uneasy, restless
Sensing changes, stirring, writhing
Dumbly rousing, wakening, hungry
Hard he stretched his sluggish carcass
Rising ponderous, vast and awful
Shedding ancient silt and ordure.
Slowly his dominion scouring
Lurching, starved, he fathomed changes
Contemplating reason's progress
Close he marked religion's waning
Powerful in the light no longer.
Close he marked how science flourished
Driving out sour superstition.
Yet he found his old religions
Still had force in nescient nations.
Still believers, prone to feuding
Fostered conflict with dissenters.
Seftis-Kotad, roused and ready
Once more worked among the people
Countering the rise of reason
Sowing doubts about the science
Aggrandising counterfactuals.
Shameless liars spouting nonsense
Demagogues dismissing dangers
Scruple-less, these useful puppets
Unenlightened feet bewildered.

Proven truths he warped and challenged
Till confusion wrapped together
True and false, now both mistrusted.
Reason drowned in tides of lying.

All across the oikoumene
Seftis-Kotad spreads his poison
Stringently dissent suppressing.
Light of knowledge he expunges,
Weeding out each skilful savant
With the fear of retribution
Driving them to meek compliance.
And the ancient stifling darkness
Censors all the peoples' discourse
Blotting out the books of record.

War and hatred, pain and anger
Storm and flood and fire and heatwave
Sure results of lies and darkness
Lay the world in ashen ruin.

IV

Should you yearn for cheerful prospects
Seeking hope as night is falling
Haply you may chance on starlight
Tiny sparks amid the darkness.
Powerless seems such frail existence
Shall they blossom, shall they ripen?
Herald they a Great Renewal?

Clear for them a patch of garden
Free from darkness, free from ruin
Drive away the lies and hatred

With your laughter drown the nonsense
Do away with superstition
Do away with gods and demons
Do away with Seftis-Kotad
Honour science, honour reason.

You yourself must be the gardener
None but you can fight the darkness
None but you can nurture learning.
With compassion build a future
Let your epitaph be wisdom
Let your legacy be light.

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